My PhD Backward Calendar

Political Science & Social Data Analytics · Penn State · Fall 2026 to Summer 2031

This is a working plan rather than a fixed promise. I want it to keep me focused on the things that will make the degree meaningful: reading seriously, producing work that I can stand behind, and becoming a better researcher and teacher. I will revisit it at the end of every semester and adjust it when the project, the department, or my own priorities change.

Year 1 · Fall 2026 - Summer 2027

My first priority is to build a strong foundation in political science and quantitative methods without treating coursework as an end in itself. I want to turn the questions that I already care about - historical political economy, state capacity, and electoral behavior - into a small number of researchable agendas. I will keep developing the data and empirical design behind my MA work, read broadly enough to understand where it belongs in the literature, and use faculty feedback to decide which project is most worth pushing forward.

Notes on the plan. I should not overcommit to too many classes or projects. The useful outcome of this year is a clearer agenda, stronger methods, and a habit of writing regularly.

Year 2 · Fall 2027 - Summer 2028

I want to move from broad interests to a defensible dissertation direction. That means preparing seriously for comprehensive exams, identifying the historical and contemporary cases that can speak to the same theoretical question, and writing research papers that can become parts of a larger project. By the end of the year, I aim to have a concrete prospectus idea, a realistic data plan, and at least one paper polished enough to share outside the department.

Notes on the plan. The main risk is mistaking an ambitious idea for a feasible one. I should choose questions where the evidence can genuinely adjudicate between competing explanations.

Year 3 · Fall 2028 - Summer 2029

This is the year to turn the dissertation idea into an actual research program. I will complete the prospectus, begin the core data collection and analysis, and keep writing in pieces rather than waiting for a final result. I also want to present work in workshops and conferences so that I can learn what is unclear, what is persuasive, and what needs to be cut. If possible, I will begin building a publication pipeline around the strongest dissertation chapter and related projects.

Notes on the plan. I need to protect time for analysis and writing. Presenting work is useful only if it leads to concrete revisions rather than another round of vague plans.

Year 4 · Fall 2029 - Summer 2030

I want the dissertation to become a set of coherent arguments rather than a collection of separate analyses. My focus will be on completing the principal empirical chapters, strengthening the theoretical contribution that connects them, and revising papers for submission. I will also develop my teaching profile by taking opportunities that genuinely help me learn how to explain political science clearly and thoughtfully. Toward the end of the year, I will begin preparing professional materials and asking for frank feedback about the job market.

Notes on the plan. This is when I should be ruthless about scope. A finished, well-argued dissertation with a visible research identity is more valuable than a larger project that remains unfinished.

Year 5 · Fall 2030 - Summer 2031

My goal is to complete and defend the dissertation while presenting a clear research agenda for the next stage of my career. I will revise the dissertation into job-market and publication-ready pieces, prepare application materials early, and keep making the case for why my work matters to scholars outside my immediate subfield. I also want to leave the program with a sustainable writing routine and a plan for continuing the projects that cannot be completed during the PhD.

Notes on the plan. The final year should not be only about finishing requirements. I should use it to make the transition from graduate student to independent scholar deliberate and visible.

Last revised: October 2026